

Great time to be a geek

December for most is a time for quiet reflection. A time to ponder the successes, contemplate the failures and generally take stock of the events in the year gone by. I, for one, don't indulge in such pursuits. I mean I'm all for learning from the past, but for me this is a time to look forward to the possibilities. And the possibilities that technology presents over the coming year are tremendous. Going by the indicators we saw very recently there are great things in the offing.

Take for instance the recently unveiled Snapdragon 805 SoC. The chip features the Adreno 420 graphics module, which is capable of tessellation and is supposed to be 40 percent faster than the older 330. The memory bandwidth is a staggering 25.6 GB/s! All of this means that the SoC is capable of delivering 4K video. 4K on a phone? Now why on earth would you want that? Sometime ago at an industry event I was attending, this same question popped up in some friendly banter. There's no need for a 4K screen on a smartphone, people argued. Agreed that packing in more and more pixels on screens – small ones at least – will reach a point where the human eye won't be able to tell the difference between varied pixel densities, but that theoretical biowall is still quite far. And who says that the 4K video that such an SoC is capable of processing should only be viewed on the smartphone's screen? With Wi-Fi Direct picking up and the possibility of speeds improving, the day won't be far when you can stream such video directly on to the nearest 4K screen wirelessly.

So much processing power wasn't conceivable on even portable PCs until just a few years ago, but we're seeing tiny smartphones surpass at least the processing hurdles. Really makes your head swirl, doesn't it?

And these are just small indicators of an age to come. From the plateauing in development we've seen in recent times, there seems to be a turning point very much in sight. When the leaders in the technology world leave their comfort zone and try to take on bold experiments, interesting things happen. Look at Apple's iOS 7 (which you'd definitely want to read more of in this month's FT). The

departure from skeuomorphism is daring, and logically a step that was bound to come sooner or later. While the 64-bit mobile architecture in Apple's latest CPU chip may not seem like a big deal right now, it is indeed a long-term enabler of many leaps.

Through bold experiments, technology leaders also gave us a glimpse of future gadgets to expect. Already we have printers that don't require drivers and can be controlled directly from the cloud. Content-oriented devices seem to be getting smarter too. The LG G Flex, for example, apart from impressing us with its self-healing sorcery, displays information to the user in interesting ways just by being rolled on its back. Other devices such as tablets have made it easier for people to access their content. No longer do you have to store files locally, navigate a file system and find appropriate programs to launch said files. You have anytime, anywhere access to your content, especially video. Be it on next generation consoles or smartphones, games, movies, videos and TV shows are all being beamed to you on demand on the device of your choice. Consumers are anticipating a future that's not ruled by a multitude of devices and platforms but rather a synthesis of high performance, interconnected, internet-enabled devices.

All of this makes me feel the technology world is increasingly moving towards a paradigm that aims to serve what you want, where you want, when you want and even how you want – and there's no stopping it. Homes are getting smarter, energy is getting cleaner, bandwidth is getting broader (and hopefully cheaper), cars are driving themselves and so many more exciting things are on the near horizon. In fact you'll likely see some of these things take center stage at the upcoming CES too. This is indeed a good time to be a geek. 



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